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that time, he was never afraid to make a decision and never afraid to take personal risk. He lived proactively and modeled a world-loving, world-embracing attitude.

We can't fulfill our purpose in the world without taking risk and making choices. Our purpose, vision, and values may be our enduring beacons through life, the "port to which we are sailing," as Seneca put it. But our talents, circumstances, resources, and interests will all change through life, as will the world we live in.

In fact, our choices are the only bridge between where we stand now and the port to which we want to head. Choices are the only path from the civilization we've inherited to the civilization we aspire to create.

Choose wisely.

Choose Wisely

Learn to use your head and your heart.

» Listen to the still, small voice.

9

Live in Freedom

Listen to the Still, Small Voice

The previous chapter outlined practices that fortify us to make wise decisions. We need to assess our ever-changing talents, circumstances, and resources. We need to read consolations and desolations and to free ourselves from greed, pride, fear, or other disordered affections that could sway us toward misguided choices.

But freedom from shortsighted attachments must be complemented by farsighted vision of where we want to go. That is, freedom from attachments becomes truly strategic only when it's freedom for a worthy purpose. Sharp decision-making skills matter only when they serve a mission or vision. It's no surprise, then, that Ignatius of Loyola similarly urged freedom from crippling, self-absorbed attachments to promote freedom for a very lofty life purpose.

All over the world, that lofty purpose is memorialized in stained-glass windows, emblazoned on emblems, and chiseled into building cornerstones: AMDG. Those letters stand for *ad majorem Dei gloriam*: "for God's greater glory." That motto surfaces throughout Jesuit documents and inspires good works all over the globe. Ignatius counseled that we are well positioned to confront a major choice only once we have rendered ourselves emotionally free to pursue all legitimate courses of action. At that point, he says, we ought "to choose that which is more to the glory of the Divine Majesty" (#152). That same standard ought to govern all our life

choices. Whether choosing careers or spouses, what to do in retirement, or how to spend our money, we ought to make ourselves free and then choose what is AMDG.

With those four letters, questions that lay between the lines in previous chapters now blink in neon: What is God asking of us? What does it mean to make choices that reflect God's greater glory? Or if we're here on earth to be holy, repair the world, build the civilization of love, or struggle for the kingdom, just how much repairing, building, or struggling is enough? A good deed now and then? A generous gift to the church offering plate every Sunday? An occasional weekend of volunteer work? Or a fully dedicated lifetime?

We sometimes speak of God's plan for our lives or use words like *vocation* or *calling*. If we are in fact being called, someone must be doing the calling. So, is God calling us? And, if so, what is God calling us to do?

Which Work Glorifies God?

Once upon a time, it was easier for Christians to answer such questions. Ignatius was typical of sixteenth-century Catholics in advising, "We should strongly praise religious institutes, virginity and continence, and marriage too, but not as highly as any of the former" (#356). The worthiest Christian calling was understood to be the priesthood or religious life; next came virginal lay life, and bringing up the godly rear were all those who got married and, presumably, supported their families with paid work in the secular world.

No mainstream Catholic nowadays, starting with the pope, would suggest that a priestly vocation excels that of a married person. Ironically, today's Catholic catechism would faintly echo Ignatius's ideological sparring partner, the reformer Martin Luther, in proclaiming that all of us are called to be holy, and all legitimate states of life and work are paths to holiness. We homemakers, office administrators, janitors, and others can find comfort in Luther's assurance that "what you do in your house is worth as much as if you did it up in

heaven for our Lord God."[1] And even though a dedicated father who changes the diapers at night might be ridiculed by his buddies as an "effeminate fool" (in Luther's words), "God," Luther continued, "with all his angels and creatures, is smiling." All legitimate work, if done with faithfulness, service, and love, is equally pleasing to God.[2]

Some of Luther's reformer colleagues went on to say that instead of worrying about whether one job is better, more important, or worthier than another, we should simply rejoice in our livelihood as God's will for us and pursue it conscientiously. John Calvin claimed that "[the Lord] has appointed duties for every man in his particular way of life. And . . . [God] has named these various kinds of living 'callings.' Therefore each individual has his own kind of living assigned to him by the Lord as a sort of sentry post that he may not heedlessly wander about throughout life."[3]

That sentiment may have consoled the carpenters and bakers of Calvin's day. But most of them had few career choices to begin with, as they frequently inherited a parent's livelihood and pursued it from late childhood until they reached death's door. Many of us, on the other hand, face far more occupational choices, not to mention a long, productive retirement. And if God indeed has appointed a career sentry post for any of us, we'll have a tough time manning that post through the downsizings, layoffs, outsourcings, and other endemic workplace calamities of the present.

Our Most Basic Responsibility

We live and work in a radically different world from what Ignatius, Luther, or Calvin could have foreseen. And so, as we make our way from one job to another, the conscientious among us sometimes wonder whether we are doing what God would want us to be doing. I've found that question addressed unambiguously in only one Scripture verse, where the prophet Micah proclaims, "What does the Lord require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?" (6:8).

Micah seems to reinforce one of our fundamental points: in a constantly changing world, the first question is no longer, What job will I do? but, What kind of person will I be? And Micah echoes previous chapters in calling us to be people of mighty purpose and noble values, people who do justice and love kindness, whatever our profession or state of life.

Jesus' observations of a poor widow add a further dimension to Micah's wisdom. Jesus "sat down opposite the treasury, and watched the crowd putting money into the treasury. Many rich people put in large sums. A poor widow came and put in two small copper coins, which are worth a penny." Jesus praises the woman, contrasting her to the well-respected, wealthy notables who donate to charity some sliver of their wealth, in part to win the adulation of their community. He explains that these people contribute "out of their abundance." Although greatly talented, they are small spirited in every sense of the word.

But this poor widow can scrape together only a meager donation to the temple. Jesus points out that she, "out of her poverty has put in everything she had, all she had to live on." She is great spirited and praiseworthy for it (Mark 12:41–44).

So what is God asking of us, and what might it mean to make choices for God's greater glory? A simple answer arises from the poor widow's example. We are asked to put everything we have into it (paraphrasing Jesus) by giving deeply from the very substance of our time, money, energy, intellect, and many other talents, and not to glorify ourselves by serving ourselves, but to give greater glory to God by serving God's people.

Thunderbolts and Lightning?

Yet even if I'm putting my all into it and trying to follow Micah's instruction to walk humbly with my God, I am still left to wonder whether God would prefer that I walk as a banker, teacher, lawyer, or priest. After all, Scripture beguiles us with stories in which

God expresses irresistible and unmistakably clear opinions about job choices. Jesus called the fishermen Simon and Andrew, "and immediately they left their nets and followed him," abandoning one life strategy for a radically different one (Mark 1:18). In an even more dramatic New Testament episode, "light from heaven flashed around" the future apostle Paul. In case those divine pyrotechnics didn't get Paul's attention, he was also knocked to the ground, blinded, and summoned by a heavenly voice to "get up and enter the city, and you will be told what you are to do" (Acts 9:3–4, 6).

He got the point, and we probably would too if God's plan for our lives were made so compellingly clear. This book would be much shorter if I could bottle that formula for personal strategic clarity. But we don't often hear voices or see light from heaven flashing around us, and we are probably wise to regard skeptically those who claim they do. We sometimes stumble around in the semidarkness. Now and then, we knowingly make dreadful choices, consumed by greed, lust, anger, fear, or a hundred other private demons. We make other bad choices unwittingly, wanting to choose well but not seeing the right path. And often, even when we've made pretty good choices, we can't tell with certainty that we've chosen the very best path and found our calling, so to speak. We feel not like the Paul who enjoyed lightning-bolt clarity but like the Paul who once said, "Now I see as through a glass, darkly" (1 Corinthians 13:12).

Maybe those stories of unmistakable clarity do us a disservice by feeding the idea that God typically screams in thunderbolts or advertises with lightning strikes. It seems that, for the most part, God speaks more subtly—which makes perfect sense. After all, if we ought to reverence each person's human dignity, surely God expresses that virtue above all by respecting our freedom to chart our unique paths toward building the civilization of love.

But if God respects our freedom (and no doubt delights in whatever creative, ingenious choices we make), God, like a good friend or loving parent, might nonetheless subtly indicate what choices

will make us happy and effective. That's certainly what Ignatius of Loyola believed. His various decision tools might have struck readers as making lots of common sense, but Ignatius saw more than common sense at work in them. To be sure, he wanted to help sharpen our wits, but he didn't believe we were relying on our wits alone and so advised us to begin every important decision process with prayer for enlightenment: "I should beg God our Lord to be pleased to move my will and to put into my mind what I ought to do in regard to the matter proposed" (#180).

Furthermore, when Ignatius urged mentors to conduct themselves like the pointer of a scale in equilibrium, it wasn't merely to secure their impartiality but "to allow the Creator to deal immediately with the creature" (#15). A privileged and prayerful communication may take place between God and someone pondering a life choice, and the last thing a mentor should do is meddle in that conversation. As Ignatius saw it, God most often communicates not through lightning bolts, voices in our heads, miracles, or angelic appearances, but in the consolations that confirm we're on the right path and the desolations that alert us to trouble. Those consolations, Ignatius says, are not earth-shattering sensations, but "touch the soul gently, lightly, and sweetly, like a drop of water going into a sponge" (#335). Ignatius was, in part, echoing the apostle Paul, who likewise said that the "fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, generosity, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control" (Galatians 5:22–23).

The Voice "in Here"

The Hebrew prophet Elijah finds God speaking in similar ways. We're told that Elijah witnessed a "great wind, so strong that it was splitting mountains and breaking rocks in pieces." But Elijah perceived that "the Lord was not in the wind," or in the earthquake or fires that followed. Instead, later on, there was a "sound of sheer

silence." And Elijah heard God speak out of that silence. Those of us who heard this story as children may remember the poetic King James language for this encounter—Elijah heard God's "still small voice" (1 Kings 19:11–13).

Perhaps, if we attune ourselves to hearing that still, small voice, we will find it whispered all around us and, more important, from within us. As the Quaker minister Parker Palmer put it, "Vocation does not come from a voice 'out there' calling me to become something I am not. It comes from a voice 'in here' calling me to be the person I was born to be, to fulfill the original selfhood given me at birth by God."[4]

And just how might we recognize the voice "in here"? The Protestant minister Frederick Buechner hears God communicating to us through our profoundest human concerns and interests: "The place that God calls us is that place where the world's deep hunger and our own deep desire meet."[5] And one of my friends, asked how God might influence our job choices, said she saw God's fingerprint on our skills and circumstances: "The gifts and talents God has given us are clues as to God's plan for us." Another friend spoke similarly, focusing on the passions and interests that not only motivate us to excellence but also touch all those who see our excellence in action: "What fuels one to perform with excellence has a spiritual quality that inspires, nurtures, and sustains one's work. . . . I find when I experience extraordinary talent in someone—whether it is playing tennis, singing, preaching, caring for the sick—it reminds me of God's grace and seems to be a very wonderful way for that person to use his or her time and energy."

Anywhere that friend sees human excellence devoted to a worthy end, she sees God at work. Similarly, the nineteenth-century Jesuit poet Gerard Manley Hopkins found God's voice and presence in countless everyday encounters: "For Christ plays in ten thousand places, / Lovely in limbs, and lovely in eyes not his."[6]

Perhaps God also speaks through our circumstances, life's unpredictable, unexpected turns that eventually convince all but the

most stubborn of us what Fr. Ciszek eventually learned while sitting in that jail cell in Soviet Russia: we don't control as much of life as we imagined when we were invincible twenty-year-olds. We learn the truth of Jesus' haunting prediction to the apostle Peter: "When you were younger, you used to fasten your own belt and to go wherever you wished. But when you grow old, you will stretch out your hands, and someone else will fasten a belt around you and take you where you do not wish to go" (John 21:18). Scripture scholars interpret that melancholy verse as the Gospel writer's attempt to explain Peter's gruesome martyrdom as something other than a total disaster for the fledgling, uncertain Christian community.

But who hasn't lived Peter's mystery in some small way? We find ourselves less in control of our destinies than we once imagined. Career plans don't work out; bodies don't respond as they once did; unforeseen tragedies, deaths of loved ones, and marital breakups shatter cherished dreams. Some dreams are not merely deferred but die.

Yet remarkably other doors open and other possibilities emerge. We find new ways to make our way forward in the world. Like Ignatius of Loyola, whose dreams of a military career shattered along with his leg, we stand up eventually and walk again. Indeed, our passage through disappointment and trauma can seem, in retrospect, a season of grace. We struggled back to our feet by our own courage and determination, but we also felt an empowering touch, as when Jesus reached out to a death-struck young girl and exhorted, "'Talitha cum,' which means, 'Little girl, get up!'" (Mark 5:41). We do get up, and in the course of a subsequent lifetime, we often walk farther and climb higher than we first imagined possible. We see that great personal tragedies bear not only sorrow but sometimes the seeds of our own resurrections.

How are we to interpret the alternately serendipitous and disappointing, unexpected and unpredictable, courses of our lives? What is happening when death or financial disaster force us to reconsider what we want from life, when teachers or mentors find and nurture talent we didn't know we had, when we succeed beyond our wildest imaginings, when managers steer our careers in fortuitous

directions, when we aren't offered the job we wanted so badly, when friends point out opportunities that we didn't know existed, or when we persist in pursuing a personal passion against all odds of success, only to find that success and fulfillment eventually come? Do such cases merely vindicate human ingenuity, resilience, fortitude, and imagination? Or is God, too, at work in some ineffable way, as Hopkins says, "play[ing] in ten thousand places / Lovely in limbs, and lovely in eyes not his"?

Well, why not both? That's how I read Ignatius, the former military commander and take-charge, type-A personality who nonetheless attuned himself to read God's will in the subtle promptings of consolations and desolations. Or, as expressed in a great mantra of Jesuit spirituality, "Find God in all things."

The Burning Bush

If we attune ourselves to look and listen, we may find God present within us, all around us, and speaking to us constantly. But if we don't bother to look, it will seem that there is nothing to be seen. Here's how the nineteenth-century British poet Elizabeth Barrett Browning wryly described humans, who so often miss what lies plainly in front of us:

> Earth's crammed with heaven,
> And every common bush afire with God;
> But only he who sees, takes off his shoes—
> The rest sit round it and pluck blackberries.[7]

The poet is alluding to the Exodus story in which Moses, encountering God in a burning bush, removes his sandals and hears the call to lead his people out of slavery and into the Promised Land.

The overarching question of this chapter—what is God calling us to do?—is answered before that burning bush. Like Moses, we are

first of all called to recognize that we live and work and stand in a holy place, "a world charged with the grandeur of God."[8] We are called, therefore, to the holiness that Rabbi Kushner earlier defined as "being aware that [we] are in the presence of God."[9]

We are called, further, to freedom from whatever shackles us. For Moses' people, it was freedom from oppression at the hands of an Egyptian pharaoh; for us, it may be getting over ourselves by breaking free from attachment to money, power, greed, fear, alcohol, sex, pride, prejudice, or any other demons that prevent our becoming our best selves.

We are called not only to freedom from something but to freedom for some mighty purpose. Like Moses, we are called to lead ourselves and our brothers and sisters toward a promised land. And we won't lead well without a clear vision of where we want to head, the kind of world we want to create, a civilization marked by "the greater magnificence of human virtue, people's goodness, collective prosperity, and true civilization: the civilization of love."[10]

Moses's call was particular to his time, life, and circumstances, and so is ours. Each of us will bring different talents and resources, live in unique circumstances, and consequently build the civilization of love in our particular way. We figure out our way forward by learning to choose well, and we will choose better still if we keep our eyes open to "every common bush afire with God" and our ears open to what Elijah called God's "still small voice" and our inner senses attuned to the consolations that "touch the soul gently, lightly, and sweetly, like a drop of water going into a sponge."

Have you ever experienced a still, small voice as you considered job or family decisions?

Do you have a sense of vocation or calling about any aspects of your life? If so, how would you describe that calling?

Create New Strategy for a New Time
Navigate a complex and fast-changing world.
Create strategy for your whole life.

Discover Your Mighty Purpose
Evaluate the world you've inherited.
Envision the future worth fighting for.
Articulate a purpose worth living for.
Embrace values worth standing for.
Put heart into strategy to give it life.

Choose Wisely
Learn to use your head and your heart.
Listen to the still, small voice.

PART FOUR

Make Every Day Matter

Get the mind-set for getting results.
Use a spiritual technology for purposeful living.